SETTING UP A ZOHO CREATOR ACCOUNT AND EXPLORING THE PLATFORM ARCHITECTURE AND INTERFACE

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Introduction

Zoho Creator is a low-code application development platform that enables users to build customized business applications with minimal programming. It provides a user-friendly interface and a range of built-in tools for creating applications, managing data, automating workflows, and generating reports.

Setting up a Zoho Creator account is the first step toward exploring its development environment and understanding how applications are created and managed. Once the account is configured, users can navigate the Creator interface, explore its different components, and understand the platform architecture, including applications, forms, reports, pages, workflows, and dashboards.

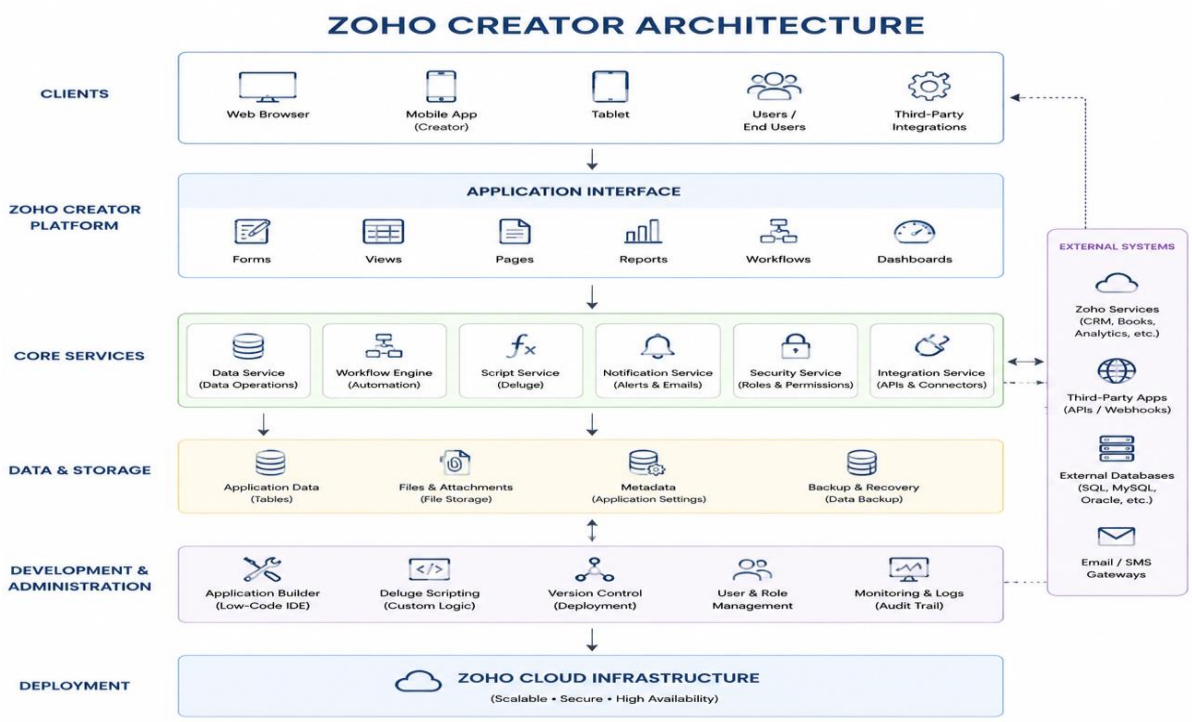
This exploration provides a basic understanding of how Zoho Creator organizes application development and how its various features work together. It also helps users become familiar with the platform interface and prepares them to create, customize, and manage applications according to specific business requirements.

Zoho Creator Architecture

Zoho Creator follows a layered architecture that supports the development, management, and deployment of business applications with minimal coding. The **Client Layer** allows users to access applications through web browsers, mobile applications, and tablets. The **Application Interface Layer** contains forms, views, pages, reports, workflows, and dashboards that help users collect, manage, analyze, and display information.

The **Core Services Layer** handles important functions such as data management, workflow automation, Deluge scripting, notifications, security, and integration with external systems. The **Data and Storage Layer** manages application data, files, metadata, backups, and recovery. The **Development and Administration Layer** provides tools for application building, scripting, version control, user management, monitoring, and auditing. All these layers operate on **Zoho Cloud Infrastructure** and can connect with external applications, databases, APIs, and communication services. This architecture makes Zoho Creator flexible, secure, scalable, and suitable for developing customized business solutions.

The Zoho Creator architecture provides a structured framework for developing and managing applications efficiently. Its different layers, including the user interface, application services, data storage, development tools, and cloud infrastructure, work together to provide seamless application functionality. The architecture also supports security, automation, data management, and integration with external services, making Zoho Creator a flexible and scalable platform for building customized business applications.



Zoho Creator Console

Before exploring the individual features of Zoho Creator, it is useful to understand how the **Zoho Creator Console** is organized. The Console provides a centralized interface for creating applications, deploying them, and managing users, settings, and other administrative activities. The major functions can be grouped into three categories: **DEVELOP, DEPLOY, and MANAGE**.

Category	Modules
DEVELOP	Applications, Components, Forms, Reports, Pages, Workflows
DEPLOY	Environments, Mobile, Portals
MANAGE	Users, Organization, Security, Analytics, Operations, Billing

DEVELOP: The **DEVELOP** section is used to create and customize applications in Zoho Creator. **Applications** allow users to build business solutions, while components such as forms, reports, pages, and workflows help in collecting data, displaying information, designing interfaces, and automating business processes. This section forms the main development area of the platform.

DEPLOY: The **DEPLOY** section is used to make applications available to users. **Environments** help manage different stages of application development, such as development and production. The **Mobile** option supports access through mobile devices, while **Portals** can be used to provide controlled access to applications for external users.

MANAGE: The **MANAGE** section provides administrative and monitoring features. It allows administrators to manage **users, organization settings, security, analytics, operations, and billing**. These features help maintain proper access control, monitor application usage, and manage the overall Zoho Creator account.

1. DEVELOP

The Develop section of Zoho Creator contains the main tools required to create and customize applications. It provides features for building applications and managing reusable backend services that support application functionality.

1.A Applications

The **Applications** module displays all the applications created in the Zoho Creator account. From this section, users can create a new application, open an existing application, edit its configuration, and access additional application options. It serves as the starting point for developing business applications using forms, reports, pages, workflows, and other Creator components.

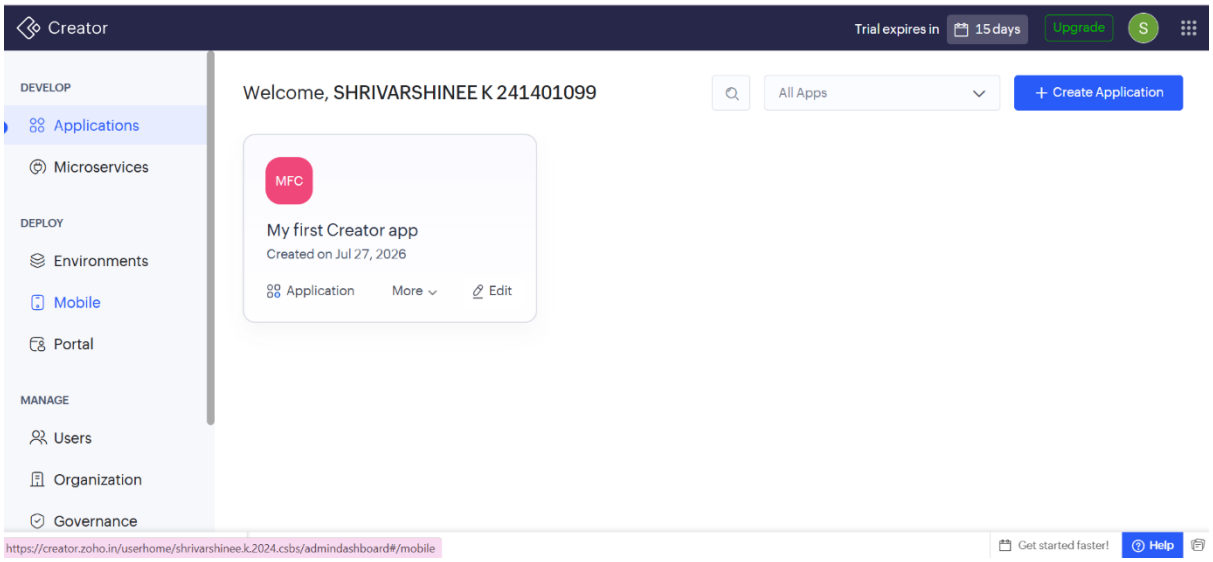


Fig. 1 — Applications module showing the sample application created for this experiment

Applications is the landing screen and main workspace of Zoho Creator. Every application under the account appears here as a card carrying its name, icon and creation date. The screenshot shows a single application, “My first Creator app,” created on 27 Jul 2026, under the account of SHRIVARSHINEE K 241401099.

● Create Application — starts a new app from scratch, from a marketplace template, or by importing a spreadsheet.

● Edit — opens the application builder, where forms, reports, pages and Deluge workflows are put.

● More — offers options such as rename, duplicate, share, export and delete for the selected application.

● All Apps filter and search — helps locate a particular application once several exist in the account.

1.B Microservices

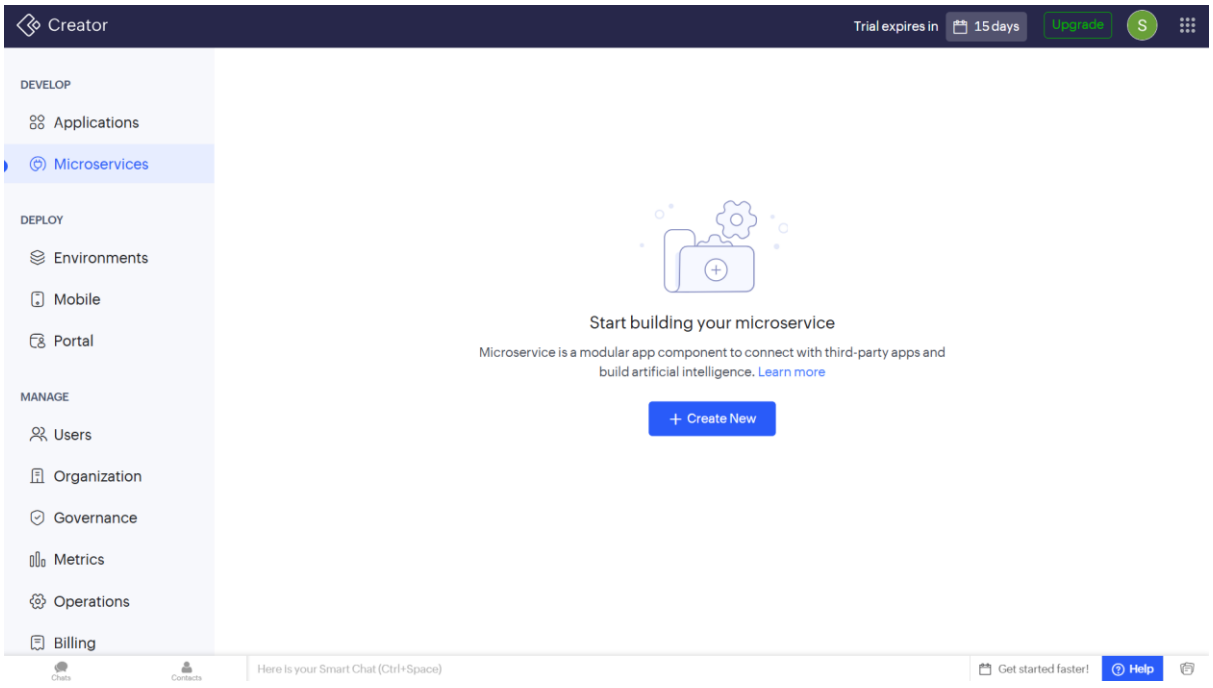


Fig. 2 — Microservices module before any microservice has been created

Microservices lets independent, reusable back-end services be written and hosted inside the Creator environment itself. Rather than repeating the same logic across several applications, a single piece of functionality — say, a tax calculation, a validation check, or a call to an external API — can be written once and then invoked by any application in the account through an endpoint. This keeps individual applications lighter and avoids duplicated code. As no microservice had been created at the time of the experiment, the screen shows the empty state with a Create New button.

- Create New — starts building a microservice from scratch.
- Provides a reusable endpoint that any application in the account can call.
- Keeps shared logic (validations, calculations, third-party calls) in one place instead of duplicating it per app.
- Learn more — links to platform documentation on microservices.

2. DEPLOY

The Deploy group governs how a completed application actually reaches its users — through a staged release pipeline, on mobile devices, or through an external self-service gateway.

2.A Environment

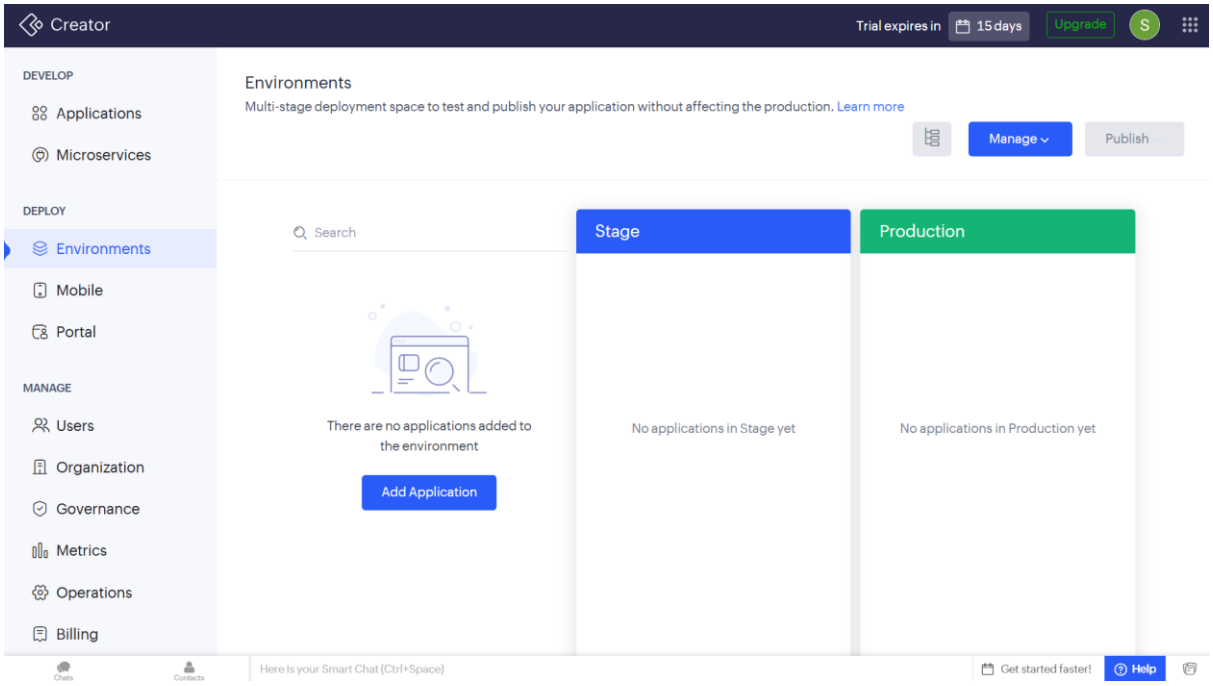


Fig. 3 — Environments module showing the Stage and Production columns

Environments provides a staged deployment space so that an application can be tested and released without disturbing the copy that live users depend on. The console presents Stage and Production as parallel columns representing successive points in the release pipeline:

Stage	Purpose
Development	The private working copy where the developer makes and tests changes before moving them further.
Stage	A rehearsal copy that mirrors production and is used to verify changes before release.
Production	The live copy that real end users work with.

● Publish — promotes an application from one stage to the next.

● Version History — lists earlier published versions and allows a rollback if a release turns out to be faulty.

● Manage — used to configure the pipeline and choose which applications take part in it. In the screenshot, the Stage and Production columns are both empty, since the sample application had not yet been added to the deployment pipeline.

2.B Mobile

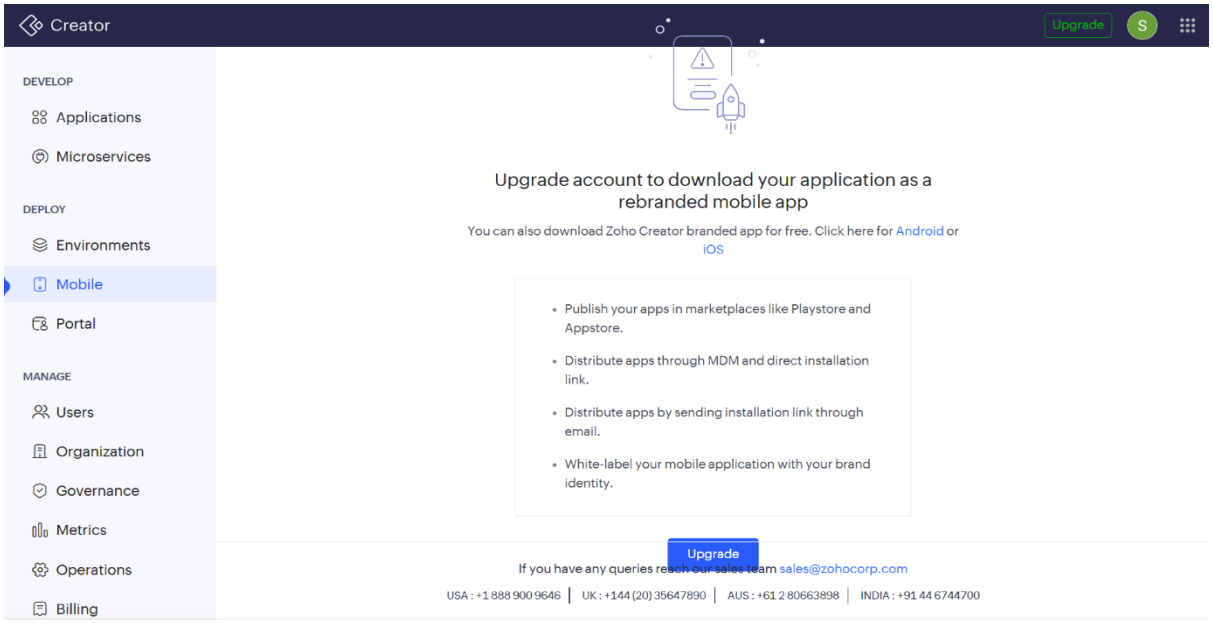


Fig. 4 — Mobile module showing distribution options for the account

The Mobile module controls how an application behaves on smartphones and tablets. Zoho Creator applications are automatically reachable through the Zoho Creator mobile app; upgrading the account unlocks a rebranded, white-labeled mobile app carrying the organisation's own identity instead of Zoho's.

- Publish apps to marketplaces such as the Play Store and App Store.
- Distribute apps through Mobile Device Management (MDM) or a direct installation link.
- Send installation links to users by e-mail.
- White-label the mobile application with the organisation's own brand identity (paid upgrade).

2. C Portal

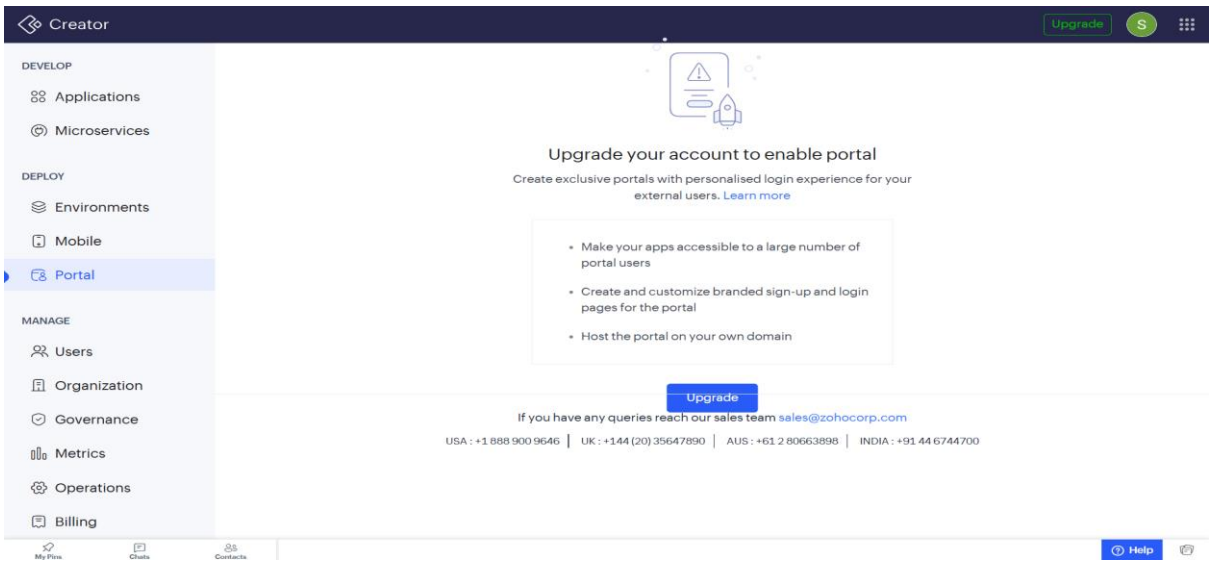


Fig. 5 — Portal module before any portal has been created

A Portal is a self-service gateway that lets customers or business partners work with an application without being a licensed user of the Creator account — for instance, a customer who logs in only to raise a request or check an order, while internal staff continue to use the full application. Since portal users are external to the account, they are counted and priced on a separate basis from internal users. As no portal existed at the time of the experiment, the screen shows the empty state with a Create New button.

● Create New — starts building a self-service portal for external users.

● Keeps external (portal) access separate from internal, licensed user access.

● Lets customers/partners submit requests or view their own records without full account access.

3. MANAGE

The Manage group holds the administrative side of the account — who its users are, how the organisation is identified, how access is secured, and how the subscription is billed.

3.A Users

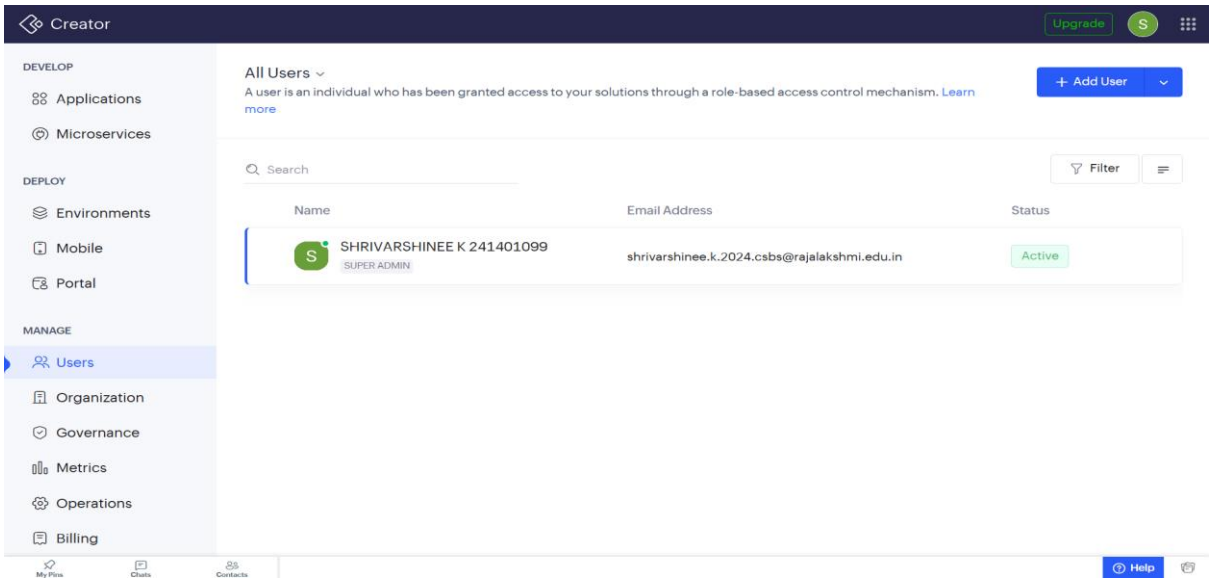


Fig. 6 — Users module listing the Super Admin of the account

The Users module manages everyone who has been given access to the account's applications through rolebased access control. Each entry shows a name, e-mail address and status. The screenshot lists a single user, SHRIVARSHINEE K (shrivarshinee.k.2024.csbs@rajalakshmi.edu.in), marked SUPER ADMIN with an Active status — the owner who created the organisation.

● Add User — invites a new member by e-mail and assigns a role that decides what that member can access.

● Status — shows whether an invited user is Active or still awaiting confirmation of the invite.

● Filter and Search — helps locate users by role, status or name once an organisation has many members.Role-based access control ties permissions to a role rather than to a person, so a member gets the right level of access simply by being placed in the appropriate role.

3.B Organization

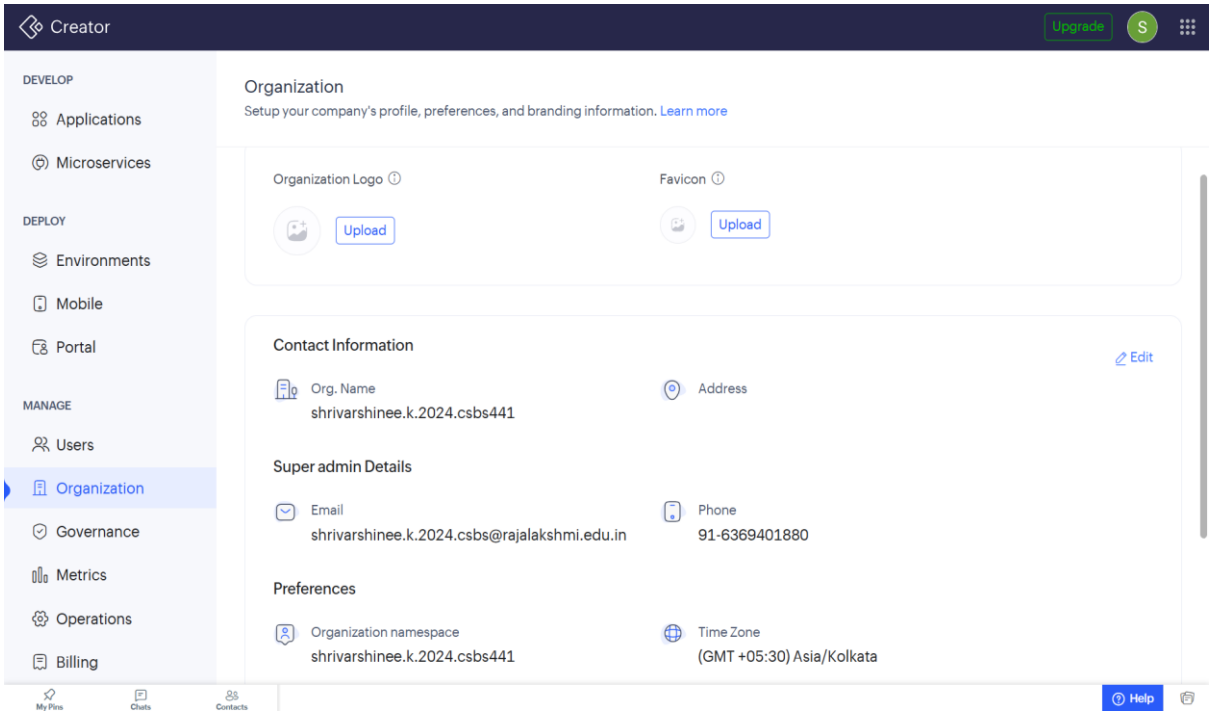


Fig. 7 — Organization module showing profile, admin details and preferences

The Organization module holds the identity, branding and default preferences of the account — the one place where information shared across every application in the account is defined.

Setting	Purpose
Organization Logo / Favicon	Branding images used across the applications and portals created under the account.
Contact Information	Contains the registered organization name and address.
Super Admin Details	Includes the account owner's email address and phone number for account recovery and critical alerts.
Organization Namespace	A unique identifier included in the URL of every application created under the account.
Time Zone	The default time zone used for timestamps and scheduled workflows — (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata.

In this account, the organisation name and namespace are both set to syedfaiyazahamed.2024.csb, and the registered contact number is 91-6369401880.

3.C Governance

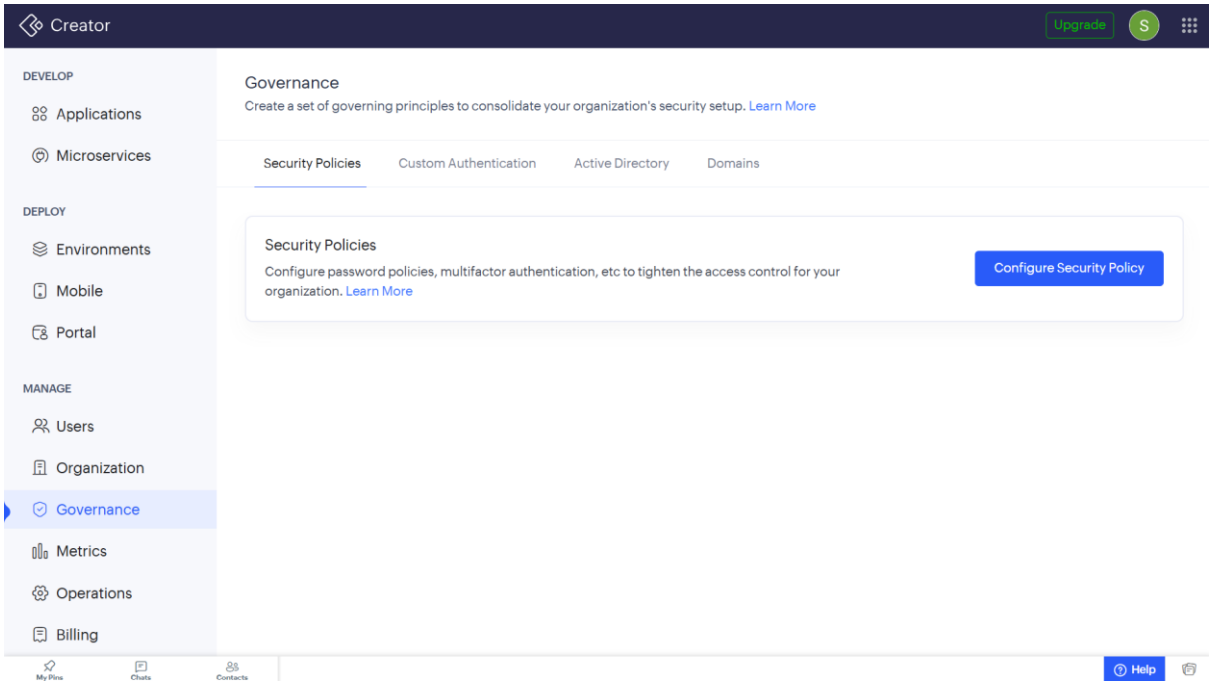


Fig. 8 — Governance module with its four configuration tabs

Governance brings together a set of principles that consolidate the security posture of the organisation, spread across four tabs:

Tab	Function
Security Policies	Sets password-strength rules, password expiry, and multi-factor authentication for the account.
Custom Authentication	Allows users to sign in through an external identity provider, such as a single sign-on service, instead of a Zoho account.
Active Directory	Synchronizes users and groups from a corporate Active Directory so access follows the existing directory structure.
Domains	Registers and verifies a custom domain so applications can be hosted using the organization’s own address instead of the default Zoho URL.